AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

The Mandate Without a Method

Why don't I know what to do with this?

MODULE 1 · LESSON 2 | WHAT JUST CHANGED | Awareness lesson · 5–7 min

THE CORE IDEA

Managers became accountable for AI before receiving a management model – and the absence of that model does not remove the need to act.

The problem is not that the change escaped you. The problem is that responsibility arrived before any method for handling it.

1 Pressure from two directions

You are probably feeling this change from one of two directions – and each tells you something different.

From below

People are already using AI tools individually, quietly, without it coming up in team discussions. You can sense that something has shifted in how the work gets made – but you don't yet have a clear way to lead that shift.

From above

A town hall, an all-hands, an email from leadership: AI is a strategic priority, and managers are expected to help make it happen. But the expectation arrived without much instruction.

Either way, the situation is the same: something significant is shifting in how your team works, and you are now expected to respond.

2 The need to act is already there

Whether or not your organization has declared AI a priority, the need to act has probably already arrived from below. The quiet activity the previous lesson made visible – **Shadow AI** – is already creating a management need, whether or not anyone has named it. Tools may be in use without shared rules. Information may be entering systems through workflows you have not yet seen. That creates **credible exposure** – a real risk to data or quality. Not proof that something has gone wrong, but enough reason to establish what is happening rather than wait for an announcement from the top.

3 A clear goal with no operational path

The expectation from above – spoken or unspoken – turns that need into a goal: make AI work well, for your team, in your context. The goal sounds clear enough. But it leaves the operational questions undefined: which tools, for which tasks, with what standards. How to handle team members who resist or struggle. What good AI use looks like versus use that only looks real on paper. What the risks are, and who is accountable.

TERM – COMPLIANCE THEATRE

Activity that looks like adoption but does not prove real capability or useful change – training completions, tool logins, or claims of AI use that don't show whether the work is actually improving.

You are told where to end up — not how to get there. That gap is why many managers hesitate: setting standards in a domain where you don't yet feel fully confident is hard, so acting can feel exposed and waiting safer. That's understandable. But the difficulty doesn't remove the need — it shows why a method matters.

4 Organizational guidance sets boundaries — the team level is yours

Even where your organization has issued guidance — acceptable-use policies, approved tool lists, training — it mostly sets boundaries: which tools are approved, what data rules apply, when to bring in legal or security. Use those where you have them, and push for answers where you don't. But none of it tells you how AI should fit your team's actual work — and that part is still yours to manage. That team-level work is what the rest of the course gives you a method for: a clearer picture of current AI use, then shared standards, workflow checks, and a real way to drive adoption.

5 A management challenge, not a technology challenge

You do need enough AI understanding to lead responsibly — what the tools can do, where they tend to fail, and why a convincing output is not always a correct one. But you don't need to become the technical expert on every tool your team might use. Your role is to create the conditions in which AI can be used well: enough **visibility** to see what is happening, enough **shared practice** to avoid everyone inventing their own rules, enough **control** to catch problems before they matter, and enough **insight into your people** to know whether adoption is real.

That is management work. **The tools are new. The responsibility is not.** Waiting until you feel sufficiently expert means waiting for a threshold that keeps moving. You are not behind because you missed something — you are in the position most managers are in right now. What is missing is not capability. It is a method — and a method can be built.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Accept that AI management has become **part of your role** — responsible for something real that already requires a response.
- Stop treating "wait for perfect guidance" as neutral — existing AI activity means waiting is a choice with consequences.
- Use organizational policy for boundaries, push for answers where it's silent — and own how AI fits your team's actual work.
- Read adoption signals skeptically: logins and training completions can be **compliance theatre**, not capability.
- Reframe the gap as a **missing method, not missing capability** — and a method can be built.

Module 1 · What Just Changed — this module builds the case for why managing AI use is now part of your role. **Next: Lesson 1.3 — AI Is Changing Work, Task by Task** — before the method begins, see the change clearly: how AI is changing the work itself, task by task.